

The Beatitudes: Kingdom Values

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Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

Ages 10-17

Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

Book 63 of 80

Scene 1 of 25

[PICTURE: Jesus climbing a green hillside near the Sea of Galilee, with large crowds following Him from below. He finds a level place near the top and sits down, preparing to teach. The crowd is diverse — fishermen, mothers with children, tax collectors, soldiers watching from a distance. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Jesus saw the crowds. They had been following Him for days — desperate people, sick people, curious people, broken people. Instead of healing one more person or performing another miracle, He did something unexpected. He climbed a mountain. In that culture, when a rabbi sat down, it meant he was about to deliver formal, authoritative teaching. This wasn't casual conversation — this was a king issuing a royal decree. And what He was about to say would shatter every assumption they had about what it means to be blessed by God. The Sermon on the Mount begins here, and its opening words — the Beatitudes — remain the most revolutionary statement of values the world has ever heard.

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Yesus netom hizbi re'ayom. Nime'altat yis'ibuwo neyrom — sinufat sebat, Himmumat sebat, jemaro sebat, siburat sebat. Kab Hade tewesaKHi seb mifwas wey te'amir migbar ab kindi miqits'al, zeytits'biyit neger gebere. Nab keren deyebe. Ab'ta bahl

*rebi kof mis zibil, silTanawi timhirti kihib yidalo alo maletyu. Zey'ilal neyru — nigus
nigusawi awaj zi'iwij neyru.*

Scene 2 of 25

[PICTURE: The twelve disciples sitting in a tight semicircle at Jesus's feet on the mountainside, leaning in attentively. Behind them, the larger crowd sits on the grassy slope. The disciples' faces show intense focus — this teaching is especially for them, the committed followers. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

His disciples came to Him, and He began to teach them. Notice: the Beatitudes are not instructions for the general public on how to earn God's favor. They are descriptions of what kingdom people look like — people who have already said yes to following Jesus. This teaching is for followers, not spectators. It describes the character of those who belong to God's upside-down kingdom. If you're just browsing religion casually, the Beatitudes will sound absurd — blessed are the poor? The mourning? The persecuted? But if you've committed to following Jesus, these words become a mirror showing you what you're becoming, and a map showing you where you're headed. The question is: are you a disciple sitting close, or a crowd member watching from a distance?

[illegible]

*Deqe mezamirtu nab'u mets'u, nisu dima kimhirom jemere. Astebhilu: bits'u'an
nihizbi biHafesha ts'eqa Amlak bikemey kim zirekib zinegir memriHi ayKonen. Nay*

*mengisti sebat bikemey kim zimeslu zigelits' geletsa iyu — Yesus kis'ibu fiqadegna
zibelu sebat. Izi timhirti nis'i'abti iyu, nite'azbti ayKonen.*

Scene 3 of 25

[PICTURE: Jesus with hands gently open, speaking the first Beatitude. Before Him, a person kneels with empty hands lifted upward — symbolizing spiritual emptiness before God. Above, golden light streams down from heaven into those empty hands. The contrast between empty hands below and heavenly riches above. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." This is where everything begins. "Poor in spirit" doesn't mean lacking confidence or having low self-esteem. It means recognizing your complete spiritual bankruptcy before God — knowing that you bring nothing to the table that earns His favor. It's the opposite of spiritual pride. The Pharisees thought they were spiritually rich — they had their prayers, their fasting, their religious performance. But Jesus says the kingdom belongs to those who know they are spiritually bankrupt. This is the hardest beatitude for our culture, because we're taught that self-sufficiency is strength. But in God's economy, admitting you have nothing is the first step to receiving everything.

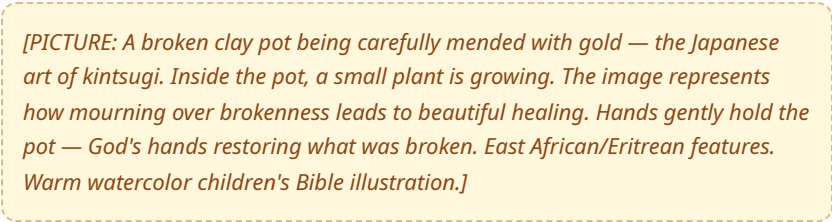
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"Bits'u'an itom biMenfes diKhataat, mengisti semayat natatom iya imo." Kulu abzi yjjimir. "BiMenfes diKha" miti'imman zeymihlaw wey tiHut ri'ise-gimot malet ayKonen. Ab qidmi Amlak milu'e menfesawi its'efa mijflat malet iyu — ts'ega'u zirekib wala Hade kim zeytimts'i' mijflat.

*yideliy" mibal maletyu, imnetiKha kim ziteredaKa zeymimisal. "AmlaKey, izi
ayteredanin. Yiqales aleKhu. Beyney kigebro aykielin" ilu biqin'ina zits'li temharay iyu.*

*Hade bota ziwesid Hazen yizareb alo. Izi Hazen bisienki HaTi'at zelo Hazen yiTiqelil —
natiKan nay alemin.*

Scene 6 of 25



Why does mourning over sin and brokenness lead to healing? Because denial keeps wounds infected while confession opens them to treatment. When David committed adultery and murder, he tried to cover it up for a year. Psalm 32 describes that season: "My bones wasted away through my groaning all day long." But when he finally mourned — when he confessed and grieved his sin — restoration came. The same pattern works in our lives. The teen who stuffs down guilt, pretends everything is fine, numbs the pain — they stay stuck. But the one who says, "This is broken. I did wrong. I'm grieving what I've done and what it cost" — that honest mourning becomes the doorway to God's comfort. You cannot be healed from what you refuse to acknowledge. Mourning is not weakness — it is the brave first step toward wholeness.

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Bisinki HaTi'atin sibratIn zigber Hazen slemintay nab miHway yiwesid? Miknyatu mikHad qusli kiHiz ab zelo yiHizo ab ziHalif gize mi'iman gina niHikimna yiKefto. Dawit zimutIn qitletIn mis fets'me niHade amet kiHabi'o fetene. Mezmur 32 neta weqti yigelits'a: "Ats'mey bimihibib milu'e me'alti beli."

[PICTURE: A powerful horse with rippling muscles, but wearing a bridle and being gently guided by a small child's hand. The horse could break free at any moment but chooses to submit. This represents meekness — immense strength under voluntary control. Mountains and green pastures in the background. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth." Meekness might be the most misunderstood word in Scripture. It does NOT mean weakness, timidity, or being a pushover. The Greek word "praus" was used to describe a wild horse that had been trained — all its power remained, but now it was under control. Meekness is strength under discipline. It's choosing not to retaliate when you could. It's speaking gently when you have the power to destroy. It's Moses — the most powerful leader in Israel — described as the meekest man on earth. Jesus Himself said, "I am meek and lowly in heart" — yet this is the same Jesus who flipped tables in the temple. Meekness is not the absence of power; it is power surrendered to God's purposes.

[illegible]

"Bits'u'an itom lewaham, nisatom nimidri kiwersuwa iyom imo." Lewahnet ab qidus ts'iHuf zibelets'e zitesasaHe qal kiKewn yiKhi'el. DiKhmet, firHat wey temet'sayawinet

*malet ayKonen. Nay Grik qal "praus" ziselTene dur feres nimgelats' yiTiqemelu
neyrom — kulu Haylu alewo ginake Hiji biquTs'Ts'ir tiHti iyu.*

Ab Tiq'at zishilim alem lewahnet bikemey yimesil? Bahlna nay mimilas Tibebe, nay zeraf melsi, tets'aba'iti zaTfi'e seb yizmir. MaHberawi midiya nizbelets'e dimts'egnan Tiq'ategnan dimts'tat yishilim. Ab timhirti bet, ab sport, ab gwijle a'irukh ziGez'e yi'iwet.

migbi kim zidelyo, bits'imi'i zimot may kim zibhigo zidileyu sebat yigelits'.

Scene 10 of 25

[PICTURE: Two contrasting teens — one lying on a couch scrolling a phone with glazed eyes, surrounded by empty entertainment (spiritual apathy). The other sitting upright with an open Bible, journal beside them, eyes alive and searching, a warm glow around them (spiritual hunger). The contrast between apathy and hunger is stark. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

What does spiritual hunger look like versus spiritual apathy? Spiritual apathy says: "I'll get to God when I have time." Spiritual hunger says: "I can't start my day without Him." Apathy treats faith as one option among many — something for Sundays or emergencies. Hunger treats God's presence as essential as oxygen. You can test your own spiritual appetite: When you read Scripture, do you feel like you're checking a box or feeding a real hunger? When you pray, is it routine or desperate conversation? When you worship, is it performance or overflow? Spiritual hunger isn't about being perfect — it's about wanting MORE of God, wanting His justice to prevail, wanting His character to form in you. The spiritually hungry person might doubt, might struggle, might fail — but they keep coming back because they cannot live without God's righteousness.

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*Menfesawi Timet mis menfesawi shelelnet bikemey yimesil? Menfesawi shelelnet
"gize mis reKhebKu nab Amlak kiKeyd" yibil. Menfesawi Timet "bizey nisu me'altey
kijimir aykielin" yibil. Shelelnet ni'imnet kim Hade kab bizuH mircha yiHiza —
nisembet wey niHits'uts' kunetat ziKewn neger.*

*ba'ilom miHret kirekhibu iyom. Ginake neti qidem-se'ab astebhil: miHret tri'i
miknyatu tegebiKaya iKha, niktirekiba ayKonen.*

Scene 12 of 25

[PICTURE: A phone screen showing angry social media comments and "cancel" hashtags, with one teen turning away from the screen and instead extending a hand of forgiveness to another teen who looks ashamed and sorry. The contrast between digital mob justice and personal mercy. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Mercy in an age of cancel culture and unforgiveness. We live in a time when one mistake can define you permanently. Social media has created a world where people are reduced to their worst moments — screenshot it, share it, destroy them. Cancel culture says: you made one mistake, so you're finished. Mercy says: you made a mistake, and there is a way back. This doesn't mean ignoring sin or pretending harm didn't happen. Mercy is not the absence of justice — it is justice tempered by compassion. It means refusing to define people by their worst moment. It means leaving room for repentance and growth. It means not enjoying someone's downfall. When your classmate fails publicly, when someone who wronged you is exposed — what does your heart do? Does it celebrate their pain or grieve it? Mercy is costly. It means releasing your right to revenge. But Jesus says those who show it will receive it in their own hour of need.

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*Ab zemen nay misraz bahlin zeymiHdagin miHret. Hade giega niHawaru ziglets'eKa
gize ninebir alena. MaHberawi midiya sebat nab ziKhfe'a himotom ziTerinif alem
feT'iru — screenshot giber, akafil, aTfi'ayom. Nay misraz bahli "Hade giega gierKa,
wedI'u" yibil. MiHret "giega gierKa, nay mimilas megedi alo" yibil.*

Scene 13 of 25

[PICTURE: A crystal-clear glass heart being held up to sunlight — completely transparent, nothing hidden inside. Light passes through it without obstruction, creating rainbow refractions. Around it, murky and opaque hearts that block the light. The pure heart has nothing to hide. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God." Purity of heart is about integrity — being the same person in private that you are in public. The Hebrew concept of a "pure heart" means undivided, single-minded, without hidden agendas. It's the opposite of hypocrisy. A pure heart doesn't wear masks. It doesn't say one thing and mean another. It doesn't perform righteousness publicly while harboring darkness privately. And the reward is staggering: they will SEE God. Not just know about Him — see Him. Experience His presence directly. Perceive Him in daily life. The impure heart — divided, deceitful, performing — cannot perceive God because its vision is clouded by pretense. But the person whose inner life matches their outer life, whose motives are clean, whose desires are aligned with God — they see Him everywhere.

"בְּרוּכִים הֵם הַטְּהוֹרֵי הַלֵּב כִּי יִרְאוּ אֶת אֱלֹהִים" בְּרוּכִים הֵם
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"Bits'u'an itom bilibi nits'uhāt, nisatom ni'Amlak kir'iyuwo iyom imo." Nits'ihna libi biza'iba qin'ina iyu — ab biHtu'win ab hizbi'win Hade seb miKwan. Nay Ibrayisti Hasab "nits'uh libi" zeytemeqaqele, Hade i'imro zelewō, siwir ajenda zeybilu malet iyu.

Scene 14 of 25

[PICTURE: A teen with two faces — one face shown on their phone screen (filtered, perfect, curated) and their real face behind the phone (genuine, imperfect, real). Between the two faces, a crack of golden light representing the choice to be authentic. Social media icons float around the curated face. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Purity of heart in the social media age. We live in the most mask-wearing generation in history — not physical masks, but digital ones. You curate an online version of yourself that doesn't match who you really are. You post the highlight reel while hiding the behind-the-scenes. You present confidence while feeling insecure. You show community while feeling lonely. This double life erodes purity of heart. Every time you post something calculated to impress rather than something true, your heart divides a little more. Purity of heart asks: Am I the same person online and offline? Do my private browsing habits match my public faith? Would I be ashamed if my screen time, my DMs, my search history were made public? The pure in heart have nothing to hide — not because they're perfect, but because they've stopped pretending to be. Integrity is exhausting to fake but liberating to live.

[illegible]

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*Ab zemen maHberawi midiya nits'ihna libi. Ab tariKh zibelets'e masak zilibes weledo
ninebir alena — gizuf masak ayKonen dijitalawi. Nay onlayin sirit niGeza'e ri'isiKha
tifeTir mis Haqegna nibretika zeysane. Nay biluts' himotat tileT'if diHri medrek
kiteHabi'e keleKha.*

Scene 15 of 25

[PICTURE: Two groups facing each other with angry expressions, a wall of hostility between them. In the middle, a young person stands with arms outstretched toward both sides, actively building a bridge. They are sweating with effort — peacemaking is hard work. Dove of peace hovers above them. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

"Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called children of God." Notice: PEACE-MAKERS, not peace-lovers or peace-wishers. Making peace is active, costly work. A peacemaker steps INTO conflict rather than avoiding it. They enter the space between warring parties and build bridges at personal cost. Jesus is the ultimate peacemaker — He stepped between holy God and sinful humanity and made peace through His own blood. The cross is the supreme act of peacemaking. And those who follow His pattern — actively reconciling, building bridges, absorbing hostility rather than reflecting it — are called God's children because they look like their Father. In a world that profits from division, peacemaking is revolutionary. It doesn't mean avoiding all conflict — it means pursuing reconciliation through every conflict.

"[PEACE-MAKERS] ARE CALLED CHILDREN OF GOD." NOTICE: PEACE-MAKERS, NOT PEACE-LOVERS OR PEACE-WISHERS. MAKING PEACE IS ACTIVE, COSTLY WORK. A PEACEMAKER STEPS INTO CONFLICT RATHER THAN AVOIDING IT. THEY ENTER THE SPACE BETWEEN WARRING PARTIES AND BUILD BRIDGES AT PERSONAL COST. JESUS IS THE ULTIMATE PEACEMAKER — HE STEPPED BETWEEN HOLY GOD AND SINFUL HUMANITY AND MADE PEACE THROUGH HIS OWN BLOOD. THE CROSS IS THE SUPREME ACT OF PEACEMAKING. AND THOSE WHO FOLLOW HIS PATTERN — ACTIVELY RECONCILING, BUILDING BRIDGES, ABSORBING HOSTILITY RATHER THAN REFLECTING IT — ARE CALLED GOD'S CHILDREN BECAUSE THEY LOOK LIKE THEIR FATHER. IN A WORLD THAT PROFITS FROM DIVISION, PEACEMAKING IS REVOLUTIONARY. IT DOESN'T MEAN AVOIDING ALL CONFLICT — IT MEANS PURSUING RECONCILIATION THROUGH EVERY CONFLICT.

"Bits'u'an itom selam zigebru, wilud Amlak kibiHalu iyom imo." Astebhilu: selam-geberti imber selam-fetewti wey selam-temeniyti ayKonun. Selam migbar niTuf, kibur siraH iyu. Selam gebari kab miwgad fanta nab girchit yi'atu.

Scene 16 of 25

[PICTURE: Two contrasting images side by side. Left: a person with tape over their mouth, smiling nervously while conflict rages around them (peacekeeping — avoiding conflict). Right: a person with hands dirty and sleeves rolled up, working to repair a broken relationship, talking honestly with two people (peacemaking — engaging conflict constructively). East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

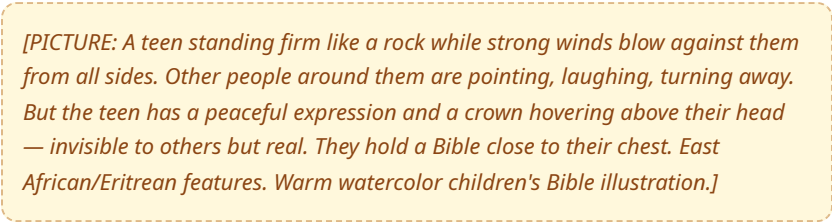
Peacemaking versus peacekeeping — the difference matters. Peacekeeping avoids conflict at all costs. It sweeps problems under the rug. It says "everything's fine" when nothing is fine. It enables dysfunction because addressing it would be uncomfortable. Peacekeeping is driven by fear. Peacemaking is different. It acknowledges that conflict exists and courageously engages it toward resolution. It speaks hard truths with love. It confronts injustice rather than ignoring it. It risks personal comfort for the sake of genuine reconciliation. Many Christians confuse these two. They think being "nice" and never addressing problems makes them peacemakers. But true peace requires truth. You cannot build genuine peace on the foundation of unaddressed wrongs. Jesus didn't keep peace — He MADE peace, and it cost Him everything. Are you a peacekeeper who avoids hard conversations, or a peacemaker who pursues genuine reconciliation even when it's uncomfortable?

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Selam migbar mis selam miHlaw — filiyu agedasi iyu. Selam miHlaw bizKone waga girichit yiwgid. Ts'egemat ab tiHti carpet yidebiq. Wala Hade ts'ibuq ab zeyKone "kulu ts'ibuq'yu" yibil. MifitaH micho't sle zeyhib zisber neger kim zelo yigedif. Selam miHlaw biFriHi yidreKh.

Scene 17 of 25



"Blessed are those who are persecuted because of righteousness, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." The final Beatitude comes full circle — the kingdom of heaven belongs both to the poor in spirit (first) and to the persecuted (last). This brackets the entire list: the kingdom belongs to those the world rejects. But notice the qualifier: persecuted "because of righteousness." Not persecuted because you're obnoxious, judgmental, or annoying in the name of religion. Not persecuted because you picked an unnecessary fight. Persecuted because you chose righteousness when unrighteousness was expected. Because you spoke truth when lies were easier. Because you showed mercy when cruelty was popular. Because you refused to compromise when everyone else did. The world has always persecuted true righteousness — because righteousness exposes darkness simply by being present.

"ἄνθρωποι ὅσοι ἐπὶ τὴν δόξαν τοῦ ἀνθρώπου διώκονται, οὗτοί εἰσι βασιλείαν οὐρανοῦ." ὁ ἰησοῦς
ἔλεγεν ταῦτα ὅτι ἡ βασιλεία τοῦ οὐρανοῦ ἐστὶν τοῦ ἀνθρώπου (ἰησοῦ) ὅσοι
ἐπὶ τὴν δόξαν (τοῦ ἀνθρώπου) διώκονται ὅτι οὗτοι οὐρανοῦ βασιλείαν ἔσονται ἰησοῦς
ἔλεγεν ταῦτα ὅτι ὁ ἀνθρώπος ὁ ἀνθρώπου-ὁ ἀνθρώπου "ὁ ἀνθρώπος" ὁ ἀνθρώπου
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"Bits'u'an itom sle ts'idqi zisgogu, mengisti semayat natatom iya imo." Nay meweda'eta bits'u'e milu'e zuret yigeber — mengisti semayat nibiMenfes diKhatat (qedamay) yiKun nizisgogu (nay meweda'eta) natatom iya. Nikulu zirzir yi'agwagwid: mengisti nay'tom alem tinets'gom natatom iya.

Scene 18 of 25

[PICTURE: A school cafeteria scene — a teen sitting alone at a table because they chose not to join in gossip or bullying. Their former friend group sits at another table, some looking back with contempt, others with guilty glances. The alone teen has inner peace visible on their face despite the social cost. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

What does persecution look like for teens today? For most of us, it's not physical violence — though for some believers worldwide, it absolutely is. For many young Christians, persecution looks like: being excluded from friend groups because you won't participate in certain behaviors. Being mocked for having moral standards. Losing social status because you refuse to gossip, cheat, or go along with cruelty. Being called "judgmental" for simply living differently. Having your faith dismissed as ignorant or backward. Being pressured to stay silent about what you believe. It's the slow, grinding cost of being different — not the dramatic martyrdom of history books, but the daily choice between fitting in and being faithful. And Jesus says: when this happens, you are blessed. Not cursed. Not unlucky. Blessed. Because it means you're actually living the kingdom values, not just talking about them.

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*Misgwag nimeniseyat lomi bikemey yimesil? NimebzaHtina akalawi amets' ayKonen
— nigele aminti ab alem gina birigits"yu. Nibizuhat meniseyat kristiyanat misgwag
kemzi yimesil: ab gele bahriyat sle zeytisatef kab gwijle a'irukh misraz. Sine-
migbarawi derejat sle zeleKa misHaq.*

*"TeHagosu bah dima yibelKum, ab semayat asbKhum bizuH'yu imo." Yesus misgwag
"tets'awer" tiray aybilin — teHagos yibil! Bah yibelKa! Yesus intay yibil kim zelo kis'ab
tird'e zeyke'al yimesil: sle ts'idqi misgwag ab qinu'e mesmer kim zeleKha meregagets'i
iyu.*

Scene 20 of 25

[PICTURE: A dramatic image of an upside-down kingdom — thrones at the bottom, servants elevated. On one side, worldly values (money, fame, power) appear large but are crumbling. On the other side, kingdom values (humility, mercy, purity) appear small but are radiating eternal golden light. An arrow pointing down labeled "world" and an arrow pointing up labeled "kingdom." East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

The upside-down kingdom — world's values versus God's values. Let's be honest about what our culture calls "blessed": wealthy, famous, powerful, popular, comfortable, successful, dominant. Now look at what Jesus calls blessed: poor in spirit, mourning, meek, hungry, merciful, pure, peacemaking, persecuted. These two lists are completely opposed. The world says: get more. Jesus says: need less. The world says: dominate. Jesus says: serve. The world says: protect yourself. Jesus says: give yourself away. The world says: blessed are the powerful. Jesus says: blessed are the meek. This is not a slight adjustment to worldly values — it is a total inversion. The kingdom of God operates on completely different principles than the kingdom of this world. And choosing between them is not a one-time decision — it is a daily, hourly, moment-by-moment choice. Which kingdom's values are actually shaping your decisions today?

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Zitegelabete mengisti — nay alem kibrat mis nay Amlak kibrat. Bahlna intay "bits'u'e"
kim ziblo biqin'ina nizareb: habtam, filuT, Hayal, fetawi, michu'e, i'iwet, geza'i. Hiji
Yesus bits'u'e ziblo temelket: biMenfes diKhatat, Hazenti, lewahat, Timuyat, miHru,
nits'uhah, selam geberti, sigugat.

Scene 21 of 25

[PICTURE: A community scene showing believers living out the Beatitudes together — one person comforting a mourner, another making peace between neighbors, another showing mercy to a stranger, another sharing food with the hungry. They form a circle of light in a dark village. Salt crystals and lamp light symbolism woven throughout. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Jesus immediately follows the Beatitudes with: "You are the salt of the earth. You are the light of the world." The Beatitudes aren't meant to be lived in isolation — they are community values that transform society when lived together. Salt preserves and flavors. Light exposes and guides. A community of people who are poor in spirit, merciful, pure in heart, and peacemaking — that community becomes salt and light to everyone around them. This is not about individual heroism — it's about collective kingdom witness. When a church genuinely lives the Beatitudes, it becomes irresistible to a world dying of corruption and darkness. People don't need more religious programs — they need to see the Beatitudes lived out in real community, real relationships, real sacrifice, real mercy, real peace.

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*Yesus biqeTta diHri bits'u'an "niskhatiKum chew midri iKhum. NiskhatiKum birhan
alem iKhum" yibil. Bits'u'an ab wilqinet kinber aytebahlen — biHabar ab zinber
maHbereseᑭ ziqiyru nay maHbereseb kibrat iyom. Chew yiHilun Ta'imi yihibin. Birhan
yiqeli'in yimeriHin.*

Scene 22 of 25

[PICTURE: A hand sprinkling salt onto food that is decaying — and wherever the salt touches, the decay stops and freshness returns. The salt crystals glow with inner light. In the background, a teen standing firm in a corrupt environment, their very presence stopping the moral decay around them. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

You are salt — preserving and flavoring the world. In the ancient world, salt had two primary functions: preservation and flavor. Without refrigeration, salt kept meat from rotting. It stopped the process of decay. And it made bland food taste alive. Jesus says YOU are that salt. Your presence in your school, your workplace, your neighborhood should slow moral decay. When you refuse to participate in gossip, cruelty, or dishonesty, you are preserving. When Christians leave a community, corruption increases — because the salt left. But salt must maintain its saltiness. Jesus warns that salt which loses its flavor is "good for nothing." A Christian who blends in completely, who never challenges the culture, who is indistinguishable from the world — that person has lost their saltiness. You don't have to be obnoxious to be salty. You just have to be distinctly, unapologetically different in your values, your integrity, and your mercy.

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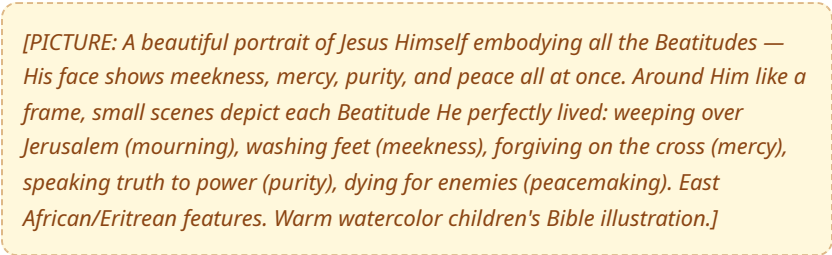
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*Chew iKha — ni'alem HaliKhan Ta'imi hibiKan. Ab Tintawi alem chew kilte qendi sirah
neyruwo: miHlawIn Ta'imi mihabIn. Bizey frij chew siga kab mibisbas yiHilu. Nay
mibisbas Hidet dew yiblo. Zinefets'e migbi dima hiyaw Ta'imi yihibo. Yesus nisKha iti
chew iKha yibil.*

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*Birhan iKha — bigilts'i nabro, aytehabi'in. "Ab li'ili keren zela Ketema kitiHba'e
 ayke'alin. Sebat'win qandel weli'om ab tiHti kulit aygebruwon." Birhan Hade sirah
 alewo: mibrah. Yesus dima nay bits'u'an qirts'i zelewo hiywetiKa kire'e yigba'e yibil.*

Scene 24 of 25



The Beatitudes are ultimately a portrait of Jesus Himself. He was poor in spirit — completely dependent on the Father. He mourned — weeping over Jerusalem, grieving at Lazarus's tomb. He was meek — all power under perfect control. He hungered for righteousness — consumed by zeal for God's house. He was merciful — forgiving from the cross. He was pure in heart — no pretense, no hidden agenda, ever. He was a peacemaker — reconciling God and humanity through His own blood. He was persecuted — rejected, mocked, crucified. Every single Beatitude is a description of Jesus's character. And this is what He's calling you toward — not a set of rules to follow, but a Person to become like. The Christian life is not about checking boxes; it's about being transformed into the image of Christ. The Beatitudes are not a checklist — they are a portrait. And you are becoming that portrait.

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*Bits'u'an ab meweda'eta nay Yesus ba'ilu si'ili iyom. BiMenfes diKha neyru — milu'e
bimilu'e ab Abo zimirkos. Hazinu — ab li'ili Iyerusalem nebi'u, ab meqabir Al'azar
Hazine. Lewah neyru — kulu Hayli ab fits'um quTs'Tsir. Nits'idqi Temiyu — biqin'at
bet Amlak tebeli'u.*

Scene 25 of 25

[PICTURE: A teen standing at a crossroads — one path is wide, brightly lit with neon signs of popularity, wealth, and power (the world's way). The other path is narrower but glowing with warm golden light, marked by a cross at the beginning. The teen faces the narrow path with determination. Behind them, the Beatitudes are written like stepping stones on the narrow path. East African/Eritrean features. Warm watercolor children's Bible illustration.]

Application: choosing kingdom values over cultural values daily. Every single day, you stand at the crossroads between two kingdoms. Will you choose spiritual poverty or self-sufficiency? Will you mourn over brokenness or numb yourself? Will you practice meekness or aggression? Will you hunger for righteousness or settle for comfort? Will you show mercy or demand justice for yourself? Will you pursue purity or curate a performance? Will you make peace or keep silent? Will you accept persecution or compromise to fit in? These are not abstract theological questions — they are the concrete decisions you make in hallways, classrooms, group chats, and quiet moments. The Beatitudes are not aspirational poetry — they are a daily lifestyle that will cost you the world's approval and gain you the kingdom of heaven. Choose today. Choose again tomorrow. And know that every time you choose kingdom values, you look more like Jesus — and the world, whether it admits it or not, desperately needs to see Him in you.

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*Tegbar: ilet ilet nay mengisti kibrat ab li'ili nay bahli kibrat mimrats'. Kulu me'alti ab
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The Moral of the Story

The Beatitudes are Jesus's most radical manifesto — a complete inversion of the world's value system. While culture celebrates wealth, power, aggression, and self-sufficiency, Jesus declares that the truly blessed are those who are spiritually bankrupt before God, who mourn over brokenness, who exercise strength under control, who hunger desperately for righteousness, who show mercy freely, who maintain pure and undivided hearts, who actively make peace, and who accept persecution rather than compromise truth.

These are not eight separate character traits to develop independently — they flow together as a portrait of what kingdom people look like. And they are ultimately a portrait of Jesus Himself. Every Beatitude describes His character perfectly. When we pursue these values, we are not following a religious checklist — we are being transformed into His image.

The cost is real: choosing kingdom values means losing the world's approval. But the reward is greater: the kingdom of heaven itself belongs to those who live this way. You are salt that preserves and flavors. You are light that exposes and guides. Live visibly. Live differently. Live like Jesus.

Key Verse: "Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." — Matthew 5:3

“Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.”
— Matthew 5:3

Discussion Questions

1. The world defines "blessed" as wealthy, popular, powerful, and comfortable. Jesus defines "blessed" as poor in spirit, mourning, meek, and persecuted. Why are these definitions so completely opposed? What does this tell us about the difference between God's kingdom and the world's system? Which definition actually shapes how you evaluate your own life?

[illegible]

2. Meekness is described as "strength under control" — like a trained warhorse that has immense power but submits to its rider. In a world that rewards aggressive self-promotion and dominance, what does meekness actually look like in practice? How is it different from weakness? Can you think of a situation where you chose meekness — or wish you had?

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3. Jesus says "Blessed are the peacemakers" — but there's a crucial difference between peacemaking and peacekeeping. Peacekeeping avoids conflict and sweeps problems under the rug. Peacemaking courageously engages conflict toward genuine resolution. Which do you tend toward? Can you

Identify a relationship or situation where true peacemaking (not just avoiding the issue) is needed?

[illegible]

4. "Blessed are the pure in heart" in the age of social media means being the same person online and offline — no masks, no curated persona, no double life. How does the pressure to perform a certain image online erode purity of heart? What would it look like to pursue genuine integrity in your digital life? Are there areas where your online presence doesn't match your real self?

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5. Choosing kingdom values is costly — it can mean losing popularity, being misunderstood, facing social exclusion, or being mocked. When has living out your faith cost you something? What makes kingdom values worth choosing when the price is high? How does knowing that Jesus perfectly lived every Beatitude give you courage to pursue them yourself?

[illegible]

A Prayer for Kingdom Values

Lord Jesus, You spoke the Beatitudes on that mountain, and every word still challenges everything our culture teaches us about success, happiness, and blessing. We confess that we have often chased the world's version of "blessed" — seeking popularity over purity, comfort over righteousness, power over meekness, and approval over faithfulness.

Reshape our values according to Your kingdom. Make us poor in spirit — emptied of self-sufficiency and desperate for Your grace alone. Teach us to mourn — to feel the weight of sin and brokenness rather than numbing ourselves to it. Give us meekness — the strength to restrain our power, to respond gently when we could retaliate, to trust You for vindication instead of fighting for ourselves.

Create in us a hunger and thirst for righteousness that refuses to settle for spiritual mediocrity. Make us merciful — quick to forgive, slow to condemn, generous with grace as You have been generous with us. Purify our hearts — tear away our masks, our performances, our double lives, and make us the same in private as we are in public.

Make us peacemakers — not peacekeepers who avoid conflict, but courageous reconcilers who step into broken places and build bridges at personal cost. And when persecution comes because we chose Your values over the world's — give us the joy that comes from knowing we are in good company with the prophets and with You.

Help us to be salt that hasn't lost its flavor and light that isn't hidden under a basket. May our lives point not to ourselves but to You. May the Beatitudes become not just words we admire but the daily shape of our

*character. Transform us into Your image, one kingdom choice at a time.
Amen.*

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Little Believers Tigrinya Bible Stories

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam

Contact: dannyshalom.etsy.com

Email: Dannyshalomnebiy@gmail.com

WhatsApp: +971525950021

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